Join the Discord!

DevLUp FSU GBM #4

Intro to Game Design

08 October, 2026

Our Meeting Schedule:

Date	GBM	GBM Title	Secondary Event	Presenter
		(No Meeting)	ACM Sep 4th	
17 Sep	1	First Meeting		Everyone
24 Sep	2	General introduction to Unity		Yusong
1 Oct	3	Roblox development (free development)		Ashi
8 Oct	4	Game play and level design		Mitchell
15 Oct	5	Modeling in Blender	Game Jam (16-18)	Sean
22 Oct	6	Pixel art		Ashi
29 Oct	7	Materials in Blender		Kaydence
5 Nov	8	voice acting in games		Laura
12 Nov	9	Music in games		Marco
19 Nov	10	The math behind game dev		Miles
3 Dec	11	End of Fall celebration		Everyone

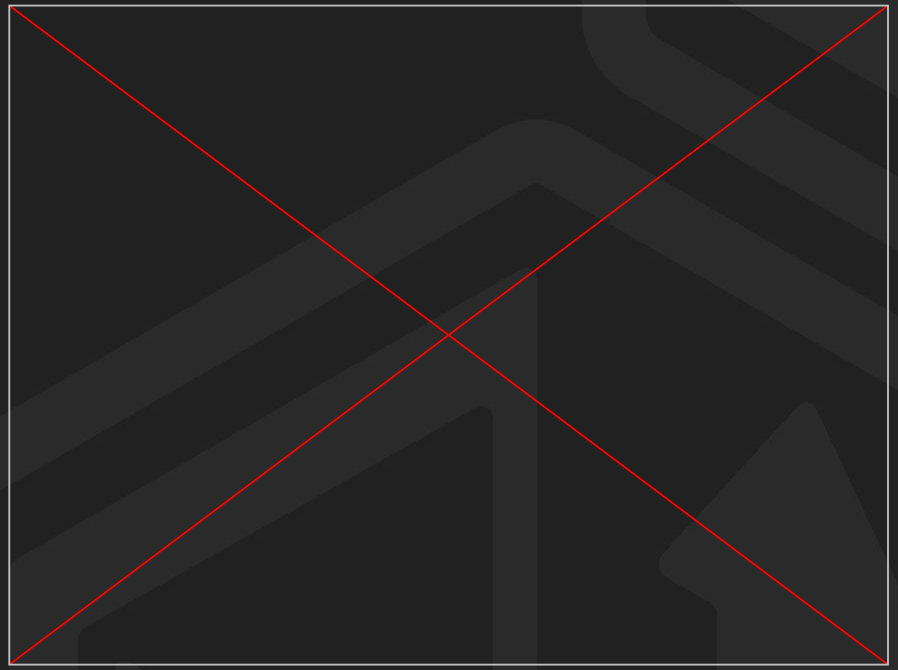
Lesson Plan

- ➔ Showoff
- ➔ Announcements
- ➔ Game Design lesson/Yap sesh
- ➔ Fun activity time


#👀showoff

Announcements

DevIUp Horror Jam!



Last Year^



This Year?
It’s up to YOU!

Want hands on experience? Get involved in this year's club project:

- Zoo VR ? 2D 3D Game?





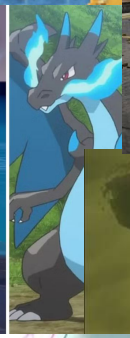
What is Game Design?

The process of creating and shaping the mechanics, systems, rules, and gameplay of a game.











Mechanics

The specific rules, actions, and foundational systems that control how a player interacts with the game world and how the game responds.

Features

The implementation of mechanics, or a multitude of mechanics. The user facing package or system that wraps the mechanics into the game.

Mechanics and player experience

Mechanics are the foundation to game design and should…

1. Build off of each other

- Percent system
- Game modes
  - Stock
  - Time
- Knockback scaling
- Ledge grabbing



Central mechanic:
Blast zones: crossing = death

2. Inform other design features

- Character mobility is just as important as tankiness/survivability
- Character moveset balance
- Attacks are built around knockback angles and power

Gameplay Loops

A gameplay loop is a repeating sequence of actions, challenges, and rewards that a player performs over and over while playing a game.



Mechanics/Features should be tailored to the experience



- Crouching/Proning/ Rappelling
- No Map/Noise dampening abilities
- Headshots = 1 shot/Limited health pool
- Destructible Walls



- Wall running/Sliding
- Mini map/UAVS/Shooting reveals location
- Automatic Healing
- Static Maps/Indestructible walls and cover

The same mechanics can serve different purposes

Case Study: Stamina

Elden Ring

When is it used?

- Sprinting
- Jumping
- Dodging
- Blocking
- Casting Spells



A combat resource



A progression key

Breath of the Wild

When is it used?

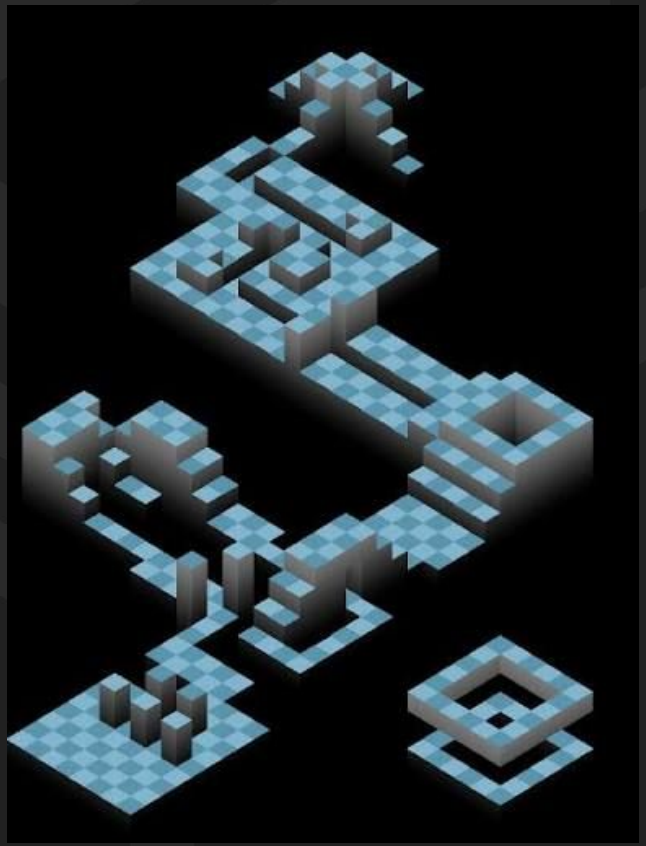
- Sprinting
- Climbing
- Swimming
- Gliding

What do they both do?

Encourage a specific experience

Level Design Basics

- Mechanics are just rules in a vacuum, level design puts those rules in context.
- Before building a level, you must know player constraints: movement speed, jump height, camera view etc.
- A level should focus on a specific objective: introducing a new mechanic, testing a master skill, or delivering a specific story beat.



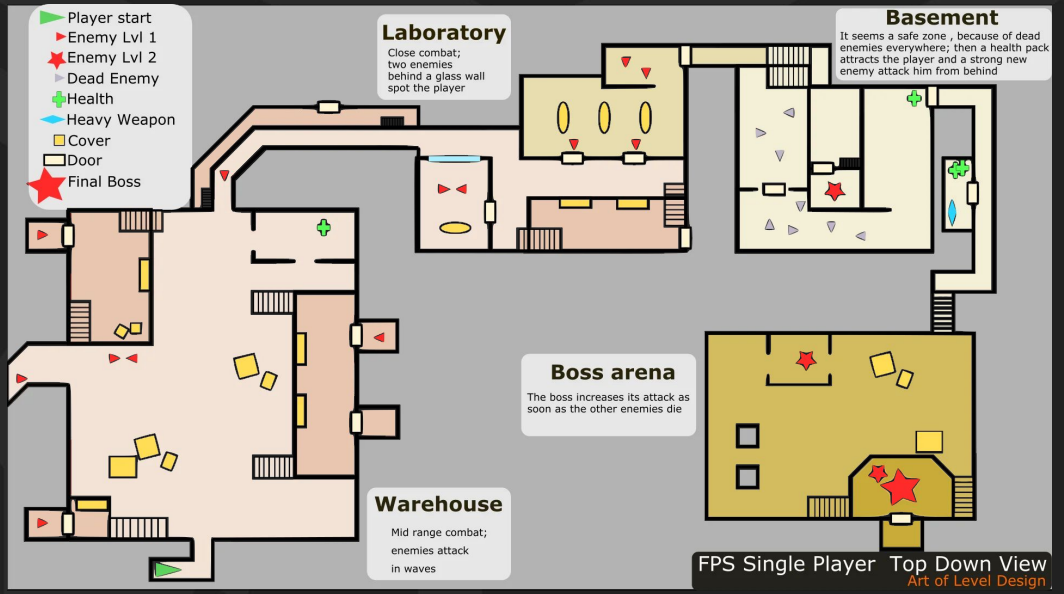
Comparing two levels

Loop: [Clear Room] ➔ [Loot & Rest] ➔ [Repeat x2] ➔ [Boss Threshold] ➔ [Boss Defeat] ➔ [Next Level]

Features:

- Large spaces to fight, maneuver, and take cover
- Many smaller side rooms to discover health and weapons
- Long hallways between rooms. Allows each room to function as a mini level

Action shooter level



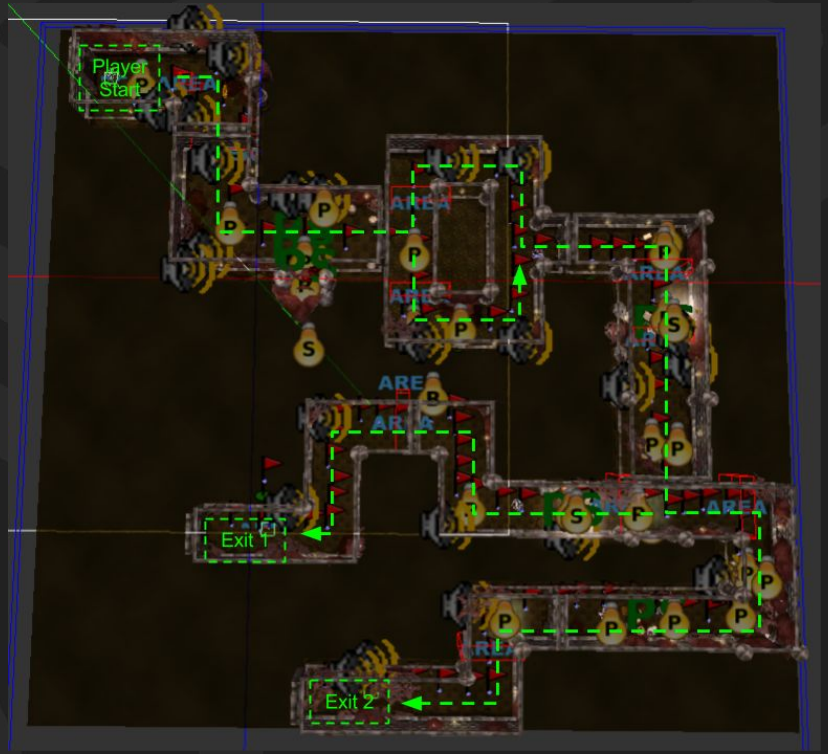
Comparing two levels

Loop: [Start Down Hallway] ➔ [Detect Threat] ➔ [Retreat / Hide in Alcove] ➔ [Retrieve Key Item] ➔ [Unlock Exit Gate]

Features:

- Exclusively hallways and corridors forcing player to see threat from a distance
- Tight walls to make player feel claustrophobic
- Multiple exits

Horror game level



Activity time

Design a game

1. The concept: What's the hook? Elevator Pitch? How should the player feel during the experience?

2. What is the core gameplay loop? Mini loops? How will this shape player experience and emotion?

3. What are 5 game mechanics that you will feature in the game? How do they fit into your gameplay loop?

4. How will the level/world be designed? Specific features? Draw a picture or just describe